The response object, filled in during the handling of the request. Normally, this object is managed for you by Rails. As we'll see when we look at callbacks in *Callbacks*, we sometimes access the internals for specialized processing.

session
: A hash-like object representing the current session data. We describe this in *Rails Sessions*.

In addition, a `logger` is available throughout Action Pack.

Responding to the User

Part of the controller's job is to respond to the user, which is done in four ways:

- The most common way is to render a template. In terms of the MVC paradigm, the template is the view, taking information provided by the controller and using it to generate a response to the browser.
- The controller can return a string directly to the browser without invoking a view. This is fairly rare but can be used to send error notifications.
- The controller can return nothing to the browser. This is sometimes used when responding to an Ajax request. In all cases, however, the controller returns a set of HTTP headers because some kind of response is expected.
- The controller can send other data to the client (something other than HTML). This is typically a download of some kind (perhaps a PDF document or a file's contents).

A controller always responds to the user exactly one time per request. This means you should have just one call to a `render`, `redirect_to`, or `send_`*xxx*